

CHAPTER NINE

The Three Tactics

The Critic uses three tricks. Three tactics. Three moves. Once you can name them, you can spot them, and once you can spot them, you have a chance.

Catastrophizing is the first.

Everything is ruined. This is the worst thing that has ever happened. My life is over.

You bombed one test, and the voice says you will never get into college. Your friend did not respond to a text in three hours, and the voice says she hates you now. A teacher gave you feedback, and the voice says you are going to be expelled. The catastrophizing critic is dramatic. It is also, almost always, wrong — and you can usually tell by the giveaway words: *always, never, the worst, ruined, over.*

Globalizing is the second.

I always fail. I never get it right. I am just bad at this.

The globalizing critic takes a single event and balloons it into a permanent identity. You forgot one homework assignment and you are the kind of person who forgets homework. You said the wrong thing to one friend and you are the kind of person who is awkward. Globalizing is what turns *I made a mistake* into *I am a mistake*. It is, more or less, the engine of shame — the one we met in Chapter Six.

Personalizing is the third.

Everything that went wrong is my fault.

The personalizing critic is convinced you are responsible for things you did not, in any reasonable sense, cause. Your parents are arguing — it must be because of you. Your friend is in a bad mood — it must be because of something you said. Your team lost — it must be because you were not focused enough on the bench. The personalizing critic is exhausting because it makes every single bad thing in the world an indictment of you, which is both grandiose (you are not in fact the cause of every bad thing) and self-destructive (you are not in fact responsible for fixing every bad thing).

Look at your own critic.

Listen, today, for one of those three tactics in the commentary it is running on your day.

You will hear it before lunch. I promise you that.



Now the alternative voice.

This is the new thing.

The Internal Critic has been talking to you for years. You have never had a counterpart. You have never had a second voice, an opposing voice, a check. That is why the Critic wins — there has been nobody in the room to argue.

The counterpart is called the Compassionate Witness.

The Compassionate Witness is not a cheerleader. The Compassionate Witness does not say *you are amazing, you are perfect, everything you do is great*. That voice is lying, and you know it, and you do not trust it — the cheerleader voice is just the Critic in a different costume. The cheerleader voice is the Critic that has decided to make you feel good in a way you cannot sustain, and the moment reality intrudes, the cheerleader collapses back into the Critic, and you are worse off than before.

The Compassionate Witness is also not the Critic in disguise. *Try harder. You should have known better. You need to be better than this.* That voice — the voice some adults call tough love — is just the Critic with a mission statement. The Critic with a mission statement is still the Critic, and the punishment underneath the encouragement is still the punishment.

The Compassionate Witness is something else entirely.

The Compassionate Witness is:

Honest. Fair. Kind. Without punishment.

It looks at what happened, accurately. It acknowledges the mistake. It acknowledges the disappointment. It does not pretend the thing did not happen, or that the thing does not matter. And then it says something like:

That was hard. You are allowed to be upset about it. You are going to figure out what to do next. You do not have to do it tonight. You are going to be okay.

That is the entire voice. Honest about what happened. Fair about whose responsibility it was. Kind to the person carrying it.

And here is the thing nobody tells you, the thing that often makes students writing the Compassionate Witness for the first time freeze with their pen above the page:

If you have never heard this voice, you do not know what it sounds like.

If the only voice you have ever heard about yourself is harsh — from family, from coaches, from yourself — then writing kindly to yourself feels like writing in a language you do not speak. Some kids cannot, on the first try, write a single sentence of Compassionate Witness. They sit with the pen, and their face does something complicated, and they say later

— when the teacher asks gently — *I do not know what that would sound like.*

That is okay.

It is, in fact, one of the most important pieces of information you can have. It tells you that this voice is new, and it has to be built, and the first sentence you write in it is going to feel weird, and it does not have to feel true yet. You are not writing what you currently believe. You are writing what you are going to learn to believe. The believing comes later. The writing comes first.

So write it. One sentence. About the mistake you made this week, or the moment you embarrassed yourself, or the thing you have been beating yourself up about for the last three days. Write what a Compassionate Witness would say.

Not a cheerleader. Not a critic.

Honest. Fair. Kind. Without punishment.

You can practice this. You can get better at it. Some of you will get good enough at it that, by the end of seventh grade, the Witness has started to talk back to the Critic on its own, without you having to consciously summon it. That is the long-term project. That is what we are building.

For now, the project is one sentence.

Write it.



A note about the cohort.

The cohort, this week in early November, is doing the Compassionate Witness exercise in Room 36. Each of them, in their own notebook, is writing a Compassionate Witness sentence to themselves about a thing they have been beating themselves up about.

Marcus writes one about the September screenshot.

Priya writes one about the *Critic-says-you-are-exhausting* line from her transcription.

Sofia writes one about the laugh at the science table.

Amara writes one about adjacent-Amara.

Maya writes one about the C-minus.

Darius writes one about Imani.

Theo writes one about a noticing he made in October that turned out to be wrong, that he has been embarrassed about ever since.

Jordan writes one about the funny mask being load-bearing in second period.

Kezia writes one about the phone.

We are not going to show you what they wrote. The Compassionate Witness sentences are private. They are private because — and Mr. Patel made this rule on the second day of the unit — you cannot fully write a Compassionate Witness sentence to yourself if you know anyone else might read it. The presence of an audience, even a sympathetic one, will subtly turn the Compassionate Witness back into a performance. The exercise is, in some real way, only itself if it is private. You writing to you. With no third party.

The kids wrote. The kids put the notebooks away. The kids walked to fourth period.

By the end of the week, eight of the nine cohort kids in the building — Mia, in Pittsburgh, was doing her own version of this work in her own seventh-grade classroom — eight of them had a Compassionate Witness sentence written down somewhere in their notebooks. Most of them had not, before this week, ever written one. Most of them had spent twelve years hearing the Critic without any counterpart. The counterpart had now been introduced.

The counterpart was small. The counterpart was, in most of their notebooks, one sentence. The counterpart was, in many of their bodies, still slightly hesitant — the Compassionate Witness was, for most of them, the language they were learning to speak.

But the counterpart was now there.

That was the work of November.

That was what Room 36 had built.